Pin

By Robert McCammon

JOEY: **(Pg 93-99)** I'm going to do it. Yes. I am. I hold the pin in my hand, and tonight I'm going to peer into the inner sun. Then, when I'm filled up with all that glare and heat and my brain is on fire like a four-alarm blaze, I'm going to take my Winchester rifle down to the McDonald's on the corner and we'll see who says what to who when.

INTRODUCTION

According to the National Institutes of Health, not only can childhood trauma cause people to re-live the past over and over, a condition commonly known as PTSD; childhood trauma significantly increases the risk of developing some form of mental illness later in life. The American Academy of Pediatrics goes one step further and calls adverse childhood experiences "the single greatest unaddressed public health threat facing our nation today."

Our young people are at risk. The result? Suicide and homicide are at the highest rates in decades (CDC, June 15, 2023) https://www.cnn.com/2023/06/15/health/youth-suicide-homicide/index.html And mass shootings? Most of the deadliest in the U.S. since 2018 were committed by those 21 or younger. (https://www.axios.com/2022/06/02/mass-shooting-killers-young-teens) *But statistics are easy to brush aside. Let me bring the issue of childhood trauma and its aftermath to you in a more compelling way. . . Meet Joey Shatterly a mentally ill young man who struggles with the compelling urge to inflict harm on others or himself.*

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JOEY: There you go, talking to yourself. Well, there's nobody else around, is there, so who am I supposed to talk to? No, no; my friend's here. Right here, in my hand. Pin. Oh, look at that little point gleam. It hypnotizes you, Pin does. It says look at me look long and hard and in me you will see your future. It is a very sharp future, and there is pain in it. Pin is better than God, because I can hold Pin. God frets and moans in silence, somewhere . . . up there.

Now, Johnny's an okay guy. I mean, I wouldn't shoot him. He's okay. The others -- I don't like the way they clam up when I walk past, like they've got secrets I'm not supposed to know anything about. Like you have secrets when you work on cars all day and fix tires and brake shoes and get that gunk under your fingernails that won't ever wash out? Some

secrets. Now, Pin . . . Pin does have secrets. Tonight, I'm going to learn them, and I'm going to share my knowledge with those people down on the corner eating their hamburgers in the safe, safe world.

The trick, I think, is not to blink. I've heard about people who did this before. They saw the inner sun, and they went out radiant. It's always dark in this town. I think they need a little sunlight, don't you?

Who're you talking to, anyway? Me myself and I. Pin makes four. What else did you have to do in that place anyway? Oh, those white white walls. I saw that Baptist preacher on TV. He said come down the aisle come on while you can and I'll show you the door to heaven. It's a big white door, he said. And he smiled when he said it, and the way he smiled, he was really saying, Joey you know all about big white doors, don't you, and how when they swing shut you hear the latch fall and the key rattle and that big white door won't open again until somebody comes and opens it. There was always a long time between the closing and the opening.

I've always wanted to be a star. Like on TV or movies, somebody important. People like that always look like they know where they're going and they're always in a hurry to get there. Well, I know where I'm going now. Right down to the corner, where the golden arches are. Look out my window, I can see it. There goes a car turning in. Going to be full up on a Saturday night. My Winchester has a seven-shot magazine. I have more bullets, too. Saturday night. Date night. I hope she's there. That girl. You know the one. She drives a blue Camaro and she has long blond hair and eyes like diamonds. Diamonds are hard, but you hit one with a bullet and it's not so hard anymore. Pin, we won't think about her, will we? Nope! If she's there it's fate. Maybe I won't shoot her, and she'll see I'm a nice guy.

Hold Pin close. Closer. Closer still. Up against the right eye. I've thought a long time about this. It was a tough decision. Left or right? I'm right-handed, so it makes sense to use my right eye. I can already see the sun sparkle on the end of Pin, like a promise.

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Oh, what I could do with a machine gun. Eliot Ness, Untouchables, tommy-gun-type thing. I sure could send a lot of people behind that big white door, couldn't I? See, the funny thing is that everybody wants to go to heaven but everybody's scared to die. That's what I'm going to say when the light comes on and that news guy sticks a microphone in my face. I need to shave first. I need to wear a tie. No, they won't know me with a tie on. I need to wear my gray uniform – gray, now there's a man's color. Pick you up good on TV in gray.

Speak to me, Pin. Say it won't hurt. It has to be in the center. In that black part. It has to go in deep. Real deep, and you have to keep pushing it in until you see the inner sun. You know, I'll bet that part's dead anyway. I'll bet you can't even feel any pain in the black part. Just push it in and keep pushing, and you'll see that sunburst and then you can go down and have a hamburger when it's all said and done.

Closer. Almost touching. Don't blink! Cowards blink, nobody can ever say Joey Shatterly's a coward no sir! Wait. Wait. I think I need a mirror for this.

(Sniffs under his arms) Ban roll-on. You don't want to smell when they turn the lights on you. Oh hell, I'm out of Ban. Old Spice that'll do. My dad used to use Old Spice.. Now, that was a good day, when we saw the Reds play the Pirates and he bought me a bag of peanuts and said he was proud of me. That was a good day.

He was a Marine. I remember that Iwo Jima crap when he got crazy and drank all the time -- Iwo Jima Iwo Jima -- he lived it in his mind a million times. You got sick of hearing who all died at Iwo Jima and how come you ought to be proud to be an American and how things weren't how they used to be. Nothing is, is it? Except Old Spice. Iwo Jima Iwo Jima. And then he went and did it, put the rope up in the garage and stepped off the ladder and me coming in to get my bike and that grin on his face that said Iwo Jima.

Oh, Ma, I didn't mean to find him. Why didn't you go in there so you could hate yourself?

Now, that was a good day, when we saw the Reds play the Pirates and he bought me a bag of peanuts and said he was proud of me. He was a real Marine.

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The black part looks small in the mirror, small as a dot. But Pin's smaller. Sharp as truth. My Winchester holds seven bullets. Pin, you're so beautiful. I want to learn things. I want to know secrets. In the glare of the inner sun I will walk tall and proud like a Marine on the hot sands of Iwo Jima. Closer, Pin. Closer still. Almost there. Close against the black part, the unblinking black. Look in the mirror, don't look at Pin. Don't blink! Closer. Steady, steady. Don't . . . Dropped. Don't go down the sink! Get Pin, get it! Don't let it go . . .

Who blew that horn? Camaro, wasn't it? Blond girl at the wheel? Seven bullets. I'll make a lot of horns blow.

Nothing's how it used to be. The whole world is turning faster and faster and sometimes I hold on to my bed because I'm scared the world is going to throw me off. So, I hang on and my knuckles get white and pretty soon I can stand up and walk again. Baby steps.

How straight and strong Pin is, like a little silver arrow. My friend, my key to light and truth. You shine and wink, and you say take your Winchester to the golden arches where Marines fear to tread.

I'm going to do it. Yes. I am. Closer. Closer. You will not blink. No. You will not. Pin will take care of you. Pin will lead you. Think about something else. Think about . . . Iwo Jima.

One jab. Quick. OW! Hurts. Hurts like truth. Yes it does. Another jab. Quick. Oh, Jesus. Deeper. Little bit deeper. I was wrong the black part isn't dead. Deeper. Got to see the inner sun. Joey Shatterly's no coward no sir no sir. Deeper. Streak of light that time. Blue light. Oh, it hurts. Oh oh . . . Dad where's my bike?

Pin, sliding in. Slow. Cold steel. I love you, Dad. Pin, show me the truth show me show me show . . . Deeper. Though the pulse. White's turned red. Seven bullets, seven names. Deeper, to the center of the inner sun. Oh! There! I saw it! Right there! I saw a flash of it push it deeper into the brain where the inner sun is! A flash of light! Please. Almost there.

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White light. Flashbulb. Hi, Ma! Oh . . . there . . . right there . . . I love you, Dad . . . Ma, I'm so sorry I had to find him I didn't mean to I didn't . . . One more push. A little one. Pin is almost gone. My eye is heavy, freighted with sight . . .

Pin, sing to me.

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AWARD HISTORY

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